

tive delivery of services without the citizen... running from app to app or portal to portal”.

For FY23, MeitY has set aside ₹525 crore for e-governance; in the last fiscal, it had revised upwards its spending from nearly ₹405 crore to ₹535 crore. And for Digital India, the government's flagship programme that aims to transform the country into a digitally empowered society and knowledge economy, the current fiscal's allocation is a shade above ₹10,676 crore (including ₹5,300 crore for the production-linked incentive or PLI scheme for large-scale electronics and IT hardware); for FY22, the overall allocation was ₹6,388 crore.

The ultimate goal of the government is to bring everything under one umbrella, where citizens can access multiple services from a single interface. And once details are entered into the database, the citizen will not have to submit them again. The government has identified key areas that will help it build an integrated portal.

AN INTEGRATED PORTAL

“While in a majority of departments, state and central government services are available online, the effort is to ensure that ‘all’ the services are available online in the near future. And given how every department stores data in silos, the next priority under the e-governance mission is to interconnect all of them,” says Singh. The aim is also to ease the citizens' experience by eliminating the need to submit the same documents time and again. “If the government already has your [credentials in the] database, there should not be a need to submit them again,” adds Singh. While the government's approach is to integrate these services, this in itself is complicated and would require a lot of work. For instance, every department will have to standardise the format in which

they enter data, say, the citizen's name or date of birth. Industry experts say that another big challenge for the government would be the unwillingness of departments and states to share data with the central government/authority.

With every government department and state designing its own app, an open-source platform could be the way to go. Work has already started in this area with DIGIT, an open-source platform and API, which developers, enterprises and citizens can use to build new applications and solutions. “The idea remains to build reusable, scaleable, extensible and deployable technology products using open-source tools,” says Gaurav Goel, Founder and CEO of Samagra, a consulting firm that works exclusively with the central and state governments across sectors from formation to execution of e-governance tools.

This approach helps the government utilise the community of open-source developers to build better solutions. “Open source has resulted in coming up with robust solutions, and ensuring that the cost of running a solution and the cost of lock-ins to a proprietary software is reduced,” says Singh, brushing aside any security concerns, since some open-source software are considered to be more secure than proprietary software. In fact, the government has been using open-source platforms for some of its major projects such as Aadhaar, DIKSHA, DigiLocker and Aarogya Setu, among others.

Another top priority for Singh is to ensure data security. “If citizens are accessing online services, they should not be subjected to any kind of loss of information or pecuniary loss,” he says. While the government is working on India's data protection law, the government's Meghraj (cloud policy), which was adopted a few years ago, provides some direction. Under this, says

Rajesh Awasthi, Vice President & Global Head of Managed Hosting and Cloud Services at Tata Communications, the MeitY empanelled cloud providers nearly five years ago and looked at three variants of cloud services, with the first type being public cloud services. “The second one, they stated, was a virtual private cloud, which you can build on top of a public cloud. And the third one was for very critical data, which they would not want to put on a public cloud; they would want to put it on a government community cloud,” he explains, adding that the third type would be a multi-tenant environment, which would be physically and electronically separate, or a cloud node exclusively accessible for the Government of India and PSUs. As part of the Meghraj policy, very critical data would be deployed at the NIC data centre.

THE DIGITAL DIVIDE

For e-governance to work in any country, connectivity is important. India has done brilliantly with 834 million users accessing mobile data in 2021, as per Statista. Through the BharatNet Scheme, the government aims to provide broadband connectivity at an affordable cost in over 600,000 villages by 2024, of which some 280,000 villages have already been connected. Rahul Rishi, EY India Consulting GPS Leader, says that people use digital services either using mobile connectivity or digital broadband. “Digital broadband, if I take on a scale of 100, is 1.6 per cent. That means, the entire population, to connect to digital services, is now leaning towards mobile connectivity,” he says, adding that the biggest challenge could be that mobile towers—with only 33 per cent fiberisation—still restrict full utilisation of their network capacity, which could become a bottleneck while carrying so much information.

The other aspect of the digital divide and a barrier to e-governance